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The Future of Technology
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To better understand the future of technology and where we are headed, one way is to examine the evolution of technology from the past to the present to the future. The first personal computer (PC) by IBM in 1982 operated at 4.77 MHz, had 640K of memory, and ran on IBM PC-DOS. The cost per unit is about \$3K at the time. Today's personal computer is much more sophisticated than it was at its inception, and its processor speed tops out at 3 GHz, compared to 4.77 MHz. A typical PC today costs less than \$2K and comes with dual-core processors running at 3 GHz, 2 GB of memory, the latest peripherals, and operating systems.

In the early days of technology, operating a PC or any electronic equipment would require special skills and often required a college education in computer programming. Furthermore, not everyone can afford to own a PC since it is so pricey. In addition, most available applications are not for home users and are not very user-friendly.

Technology has changed so much since its inception. Today's technology can include a personal computer, a PDA, wireless networking, a cell phone, an iPod, any home network appliances, or any other digital electronics. These digital devices are becoming part of people's lives and are responsible for bringing, delivering, and connecting schools, businesses, and people together from virtually anywhere in the world. In addition, operating a personal computer and software (e.g., Windows XP) is becoming common knowledge for all people, including K-5 students and people from minority backgrounds, especially people with disabilities. Basically, every person who grows up today knows

how to use or is familiar with technology, and in a short time, he/she is able to operate a device with minimal instruction. User-friendly, minimum instructions, and plug-and-play are a few terminologies described in concept maps.

Today's technology is also an essential means of communicating and connecting with people, as well as running a business. Many schools, colleges, and universities have also embraced technology infrastructure as part of their institutional fabric. Many applications, such as operational software (financial, accounting, Microsoft Office System, and so on), the Internet, and email, are essential to their institutional operations. There is no question that administrators, staff, and faculty have access to these technologies, but students do as well. Most students are already familiar with Microsoft Excel and Microsoft Word, Web pages, and email applications. Some of the features in these applications allow user-defined content, which is considered a mindtool application.

Technology has experienced exponential growth in the past 30 years, and it can only grow much faster. Not only do the Internet, Weblogs, online chat, instant messaging, cell phones, and email provide new ways for people to interconnect, but the technology sector as a whole is still growing and expanding very rapidly. There is a new movement of the Internet about Web 2.0, which is a new generation of web documents that have morphed into a web of data. With Web 2.0, users are no longer just looking at the same old sources for information, but they are looking to a set of tools to aggregate and remix microcontents in new and useful ways. The effects of Web 2.0 are far-reaching. Like all paradigm shifts, it affects the people who use it socially, culturally, and even politically. Users of these technologies use virtualization tools, hypermedia, etc.

All together, I believe that understanding the past will shed light on the present. If we can't understand the past, how can we understand the present? I believe that technology continues to shape businesses, colleges, and universities; therefore, it is important for future leaders in education to keep current with the latest technology.

The future of higher education: I believe teachers and students are united in learning and need to collaborate and learn in teams. Technology and software applications are cornerstones for connecting them.

Finally, I believe that future technology will transform the way people live, work, and play, and that such applications will help people boost their productivity.